

QUALITY OVER QUANTITY
Organic brand Veggie Culture's farm in Noida, UP

National Mission for Clean Ganga. Officials say Rs 120.49 crore has already been released for 6,181 clusters. PM Modi had in December called upon the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) to scientifically validate natural farming and promote it as a mass movement. He also called on farmers to experiment in their fields, initially on small patches, eventually expanding to their entire holding. On cue, ICAR has started developing course content for natural farming and allied organic techniques.

STARTING SMALL

The agriculture ministry is setting smaller, achievable targets. Officials say their focus is on promoting chemical-free agriculture in tribal, hilly and agro-forestry areas. The hilly terrain of smaller states like Meghalaya, Mizoram, Uttarakhand and Goa have some 10 per cent of their farmland dedicated to organic cultivation. Sikkim tops the list with a determined 100 per cent. Uttarakhand made some effort in 2019, passing legislation to declare 10 blocks—Dunda, Pratapnagar, Jaiharikhal, Jakholi, Agustmuni, Ukhimath, Dewal, Salt, Betalghat and Munsiyari—completely organic. It has also criminalised the sale and purchase of chemical fertilisers and pesticides in these blocks. However, it is the bigger states that have to do the catching up: their figures for organic farming are embarrassingly small. MP has 4.9 per cent, Rajasthan 2 per cent and Maharashtra just 1.6 per cent of their farms dedicated to organic produce. Upping these figures will require establishing mechanisms to assist farmers in various aspects, be it production, certification or access to marketing networks—all work in progress.

Punjab is a story by itself, with some plot elements specific to it. Some 85 per cent of its crops—paddy, wheat and cotton—are procured by central agencies such as the Food

THE GREEN GLOSSARY

NATURAL FARMING
Only natural, farm-based pesticides, insecticides like Dashparni Ark and Neem Astra, and natural crop nutrients, like weed mulch, are used, not chemicals. The local breeds of seeds, native varieties of vegetables, grains, pulses and other crops are grown. Quality is good and is dependent on the weather and other external factors.

ORGANIC FARMING
Organic fertilisers and manures like compost, vermicompost and manure are used and added to the farms externally. Organic farming requires bulk manure and has an ecological impact on the surrounding environments. Quality is good, but the quantity is less.

CONVENTIONAL FARMING
Relies on chemical intervention to fight pests, weeds, insects along with providing plant nutrition to produce more yield. Focus is on increasing quantity. Quality remains questionable.

